



Chronic Illness



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What Chronic Illness Taught Me About Strength

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Amna's story of living with a tracheostomy, pursuing dreams, and redefining strength

The Beginning of My Journey

I believe the root of my pain and lifelong challenges lies in a severe episode of meningitis that I suffered during early childhood. Before that, I was a healthy and active child, but the illness altered my neurological functioning and changed the course of my life forever. It resulted in the loss of upper limb power and left me dependent on a tracheostomy tube, a reality I have lived with for more than twenty years. I spent five and a half months on ventilator support in the Pediatric Intensive Care Unit, enduring uncertainty and countless medical interventions. Over the years, I have learned to manage these challenges through medical care, adaptation, determination, and an unwavering commitment to living a purposeful life.



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Learning to Accept a Lifelong Condition

Accepting that my condition would be lifelong was not easy. As I matured, I gradually realized that certain vulnerabilities would always remain part of my journey. There were moments of grief, frustration, and questioning, but

I eventually learned that acceptance does not mean surrender.

Instead, it means embracing life as it is while continuing to strive for growth and achievement. My faith, unwavering support of my parents and brothers and my education became the foundations upon which I rebuilt my confidence and sense of purpose.

Pursuing Education and Purpose

These ongoing adversities have influenced every aspect of my daily life. Activities that many people take for granted often require careful planning, patience, or assistance. Yet I refused to allow my circumstances to limit my aspirations. I pursued higher education with determination, completed my law degree, earned distinctions in multiple academic programs, qualified UGC NET-JRF in Human Rights on my first attempt, and am currently pursuing a PhD in Social Work. My research focuses on the psychosocial implications of tracheostomy on individuals and families, a topic deeply connected to my own lived experience.



I refused to let my circumstances define my future. Today, I am pursuing a PhD in Social Work, inspired by my own lived experience.

The Support That Sustained Me

One of the greatest blessings throughout this journey has been the unwavering support of my family, whose love and sacrifices have sustained me through every challenge. Equally significant has been the role of Dr. Urmila Jhamb, whose contribution to my life is impossible to express in words alone. Despite her demanding responsibilities as a Professor and Director In-Charge at Lok Nayak Hospital, Delhi, she has stood by me throughout my journey. Her role has been far greater than that of a physician. She has been a mentor, a guiding light, a source of strength, and at times, a member of my extended family. Her compassion, encouragement, and belief in my potential helped me see possibilities where others saw limitations. For her support and kindness, I will remain grateful throughout my life.

What Chronic Illness Has Taught Me

Living with chronic health challenges has transformed me profoundly. It has taught me patience, empathy, resilience, and gratitude. It has made me more aware of the struggles of others and strengthened my commitment to advocating for inclusion,

human rights, and social justice. Rather than viewing vulnerability as weakness, I have come to understand it as a source of courage, insight, and connection.

Healing Through Research and Reflection

When faced with overwhelming moments, I turn to prayer, reflection, reading, and academic work. Research has become both an intellectual pursuit and a form of healing, allowing me to transform personal experiences into knowledge that may benefit others. I have also noticed that emotional well-being and physical health are deeply interconnected. Stress and anxiety often intensify physical discomfort, while hope, meaningful relationships, and a sense of purpose help me navigate challenges more effectively.

Redefining Wellness, Strength, and Identity

This journey has completely reshaped my understanding of wellness, strength, and identity. Wellness is not merely the absence of illness; it is the ability to live meaningfully despite adversity. Strength is not measured solely by physical ability but by resilience, perseverance, and the determination to keep moving forward despite obstacles.

My identity extends far beyond my medical condition.

I am a researcher, scholar, advocate, daughter, sister, and someone deeply committed to creating positive change through knowledge and service.

The Invisible Effort Behind Everyday Life

One aspect of living with chronic challenges that people often struggle to understand is the invisible effort required to navigate everyday life. Many see accomplishments but not the countless adjustments, uncertainties, and emotional burdens behind them. Strength and struggle often coexist, even when one is not immediately visible.

The Meaning of Support and Connection

My experiences have also reshaped my relationships. They have shown me the true meaning of support and revealed unexpected allies in healthcare professionals, mentors, colleagues, and individuals facing similar struggles. Through these connections, I have learned that resilience is rarely built alone; it grows through compassion, understanding, and shared humanity.

A Message for Others Living with Chronic Pain

To anyone who is beginning to come to terms with living with chronic pain, medical vulnerability, or long-term adversity, I would say this: allow yourself time to grieve, but never abandon hope. Life may unfold differently from what you once imagined, but it can still be filled with achievement, purpose, and joy. Be patient with yourself, seek support when needed, and celebrate every step forward.

Your circumstances are only one chapter of your story, not its conclusion.

My own journey has taught me that hope can be stronger than fear, resilience can overcome adversity, and even the most difficult experiences can become a source of strength, purpose, and inspiration.

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Amna is a human rights advocate and Senior Research Fellow (SRF) in Social Work at Jamia Millia Islamia. She completed her Master's in Human Rights and Duties Education with distinction, followed by an Advanced Diploma in Public Health from the Department of Social Work, JMI. She qualified the UGC NET-JRF in Social Work on her very first attempt and is currently pursuing a PhD in Social Work, alongside completing a one-year PG Diploma in Guidance and Counselling. Her journey and work have also been featured in London Horizon Magazine. Aamna has pursued all her higher education, from graduation to PhD level, at Jamia Millia Islamia University. She has a keen and deep interest in reading and writing, and loves exploring nature and meaningful new-age content.

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Written by Pratik Aggarwal

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Constantly being in acute pain can be daunting and often a lonely journey. It is a space to rise and fall in stories of pain, healing, and co-existence.
